In February, the price of local produce fluctuated by more than 100 percent above the five-year average. The price of a six-pound pot of local maize grain has increased by almost 69 percent compared to last year, increasing from 215 HTG in February 2022 to around 427 HTG in February 2023, while local black beans have risen by almost 57 percent over the same period, going from 616 HTG to around 1,084 HTG. There are multiple factors driving this rise, notably higher production costs and a below-average harvest due to erratic rainfall. Compared to the average of the last five years, the price of these two local products in February fluctuated between 115 and 128 percent.

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As with local food products, the price of imported food has risen year on year in comparison with the five-year average, due mainly to inflation. The price of all types of rice is 103 percent above average for the month of February. A six-pound pot is currently sold at the market for 669 HTG, compared to 316 HTG in February 2022.

Fall growing season: Government estimates for total agricultural production in Haiti are not available. However, remotely sensed data and field information indicate that fall crops will be below normal. Between September and December, below- average and poorly distributed rainfall negatively impacted autumn and winter crop growth in all regions. The lack of agricultural inputs, particularly seeds, and the high price of fertilizer have significantly reduced planted areas. Beans—usually produced in Haiti at levels that range from self-sufficiency to surplus—are one of the most affected crops. It should be noted that plantations in Bas Artibonite, Haiti's largest area of rice production, have been subject not only to the effects of drought and violent winds in December and January but also to attacks by armed gangs that have forced farmers to flee production areas.

Rainfall conditions: The country usually records an average rainfall of 10 millimeters in January and February. Although rainfall data at the beginning of January 2023 indicated a slight increase compared to average, particularly in the humid mountain areas, rainfall totals were below normal by the end of February. This has led to water deficits in the country's production areas, including the North-West, South, South-East, Haut Artibonite, North-East, Haut Plateau, Nippes, and Grand'Anse, thus impacting the start of spring season activities.

In the semi-humid mountains (South, Nippes, North-East, West) and irrigated areas, beans, maize, lagoon rice, roots, tubers, bananas, and sorghum were harvested in February. Despite the drought, and in anticipation of the first rains, soil preparation is underway throughout most of the country. The departments of the South and Grand'Anse usually begin their spring growing

season in January and February, with the first rainy season in January. But this year, because of the late rains, it has not yet begun.

Livestock conditions: In the semi-humid regions and those with close-to-normal rainfall, livestock conditions are stable thanks to the availability of water, feed, and veterinary care. The situation is different in areas impacted by drought since November, including the North-West, North-East, South, South-East, and Grand'Anse. Diseases such as Teshen (affecting pigs) and Newcastle disease (affecting poultry) are common in these regions. According to reports by key informants, there have been large numbers of deaths among these species, particularly in Grand'Anse in the communes of Corail, Anse-d'Hainaut, Dame-Marie and Irois, among others. However, there are no verified estimates of pig and poultry deaths.

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Sources of income: In rural areas, poor households mainly rely on income from labor, wood and charcoal sales, and fishing. Wood and charcoal sales, an important source of income particularly for poor households in the HT01 livelihood zone, are close to normal, although households are forced to intensify their efforts to access wood resources as these become increasingly scarce, particularly in Grand'Anse and the South.

In fishing areas like the South Coast, North-East, Nippes, Grand'Anse, South-East and North-West, there is currently a seasonal slowdown in activities, leading to a decrease in the availability of fishery products. The sector is also facing a lack of adequate equipment, which could limit production and reduce incomes. This is particularly the case on the South Coast (Les Anglais, Port-à-Piment, Tiburon) as fishing equipment cannot be transported from Port-au-Prince because of insecurity on National Road 2.

Income from agricultural labor was below average during the winter cropping season due to the reduced ability of better-off households to hire laborers and various climatic, sociopolitical, and economic shocks that reduced their capacity to invest. However, with preparations for the spring agricultural season underway, there is a seasonal increase in demand for labor in various locations. As a result, labor costs have increased, varying from 250 HTG to 700 HTG per day. Last year at this time, the cost of labor was between 200 HTG to 400 HTG per day. Nevertheless, because the increase in income from labor is not proportionate with the rate of inflation, the purchasing power of agricultural workers has declined. To meet their needs, poor and very poor households in areas where agriculture is the main source of income are turning to occasional subsistence and low-paying activities such as manual labor for construction. Some women do laundry for middle-income or better-off urban households.